

ORAKZAI WITHIN THE KARLANI SYSTEM

Pashtun Karlani Orakzai Tribal Structure Family Individual

To understand Orakzai identity, it is useful to look one level beyond the tribe itself. Orakzai belongs to the wider Pashtun world. Within traditional Pashtun genealogical classifications, Orakzai is commonly associated with the Karlani grouping.

But Karlani is not another name for Orakzai. It is a wider framework through which a number of Pashtun communities have traditionally been connected. A person may identify as Pashtun, Karlani in a traditional genealogical sense, Orakzai at the tribal level, and with a particular family or lineage at the local level. These identities exist simultaneously.

THE LAYERS OF IDENTITY

PASHTUN

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KARLANI

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ORAKZAI

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ORAKZAI TRIBAL BRANCHES

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FAMILY / LINEAGE

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Traditional genealogical and historical classification — not a genetic ancestry chart.

WHAT KARLANI MEANS HERE

In this context, Karlani is understood as a traditional tribal and genealogical classification. It is not a country, a modern political party, a centralized government, a single tribe, or a scientifically established biological population. Rather, it represents a wider historical framework in which several Pashtun communities have traditionally shared genealogical narratives.¹

KARLANI = broader traditional genealogical grouping

ORAKZAI = distinct Pashtun tribe

Identifying Orakzai as Karlani does not remove the distinct historical identity of the Orakzai people. The same principle applies to other communities traditionally associated with Karlani, such as the Afridi, Khattak, Wazir, Mehsud, and Bangash.²

THE ORAKZAI HOMELAND AND TIRAH

The Orakzai have historically been associated with the mountainous region of northwestern present-day Pakistan, particularly the region historically known as Orakzai territory and the surrounding Tirah highlands. This broader geographic area connects with Kohat, Kurram, and Khyber.³

These are regional concentrations and historical associations rather than permanent ancient borders. Tribal settlement shifted over time through migration, conflict, alliances, and political administration.

Linguistic research, such as dialectological studies from the University of Malakand examining Pashto varieties in the northwest, highlights phonetic and lexical connections among Karlani-associated groups like Orakzai and Bangash. However, linguistic similarity does not automatically prove common biological ancestry.⁴

Similarly, while Orakzai and Afridi share neighboring territory in the Khyber/Tirah region and belong to the Karlani classification, Orakzai $\neq$ Afridi. Neighboring tribal communities share geographic space, trade routes, and cultural influences without being the same tribe.

TRIBE + LANGUAGE + GEOGRAPHY + HISTORY = IDENTITY

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

The Karlani connection places Orakzai within a broader Pashtun historical framework, providing rich context without erasing our separate tribal identity. Our roots are nourished by shared mountain geography, oral memory, and a distinct Orakzai spirit that bridges ancestral tradition with the modern world.